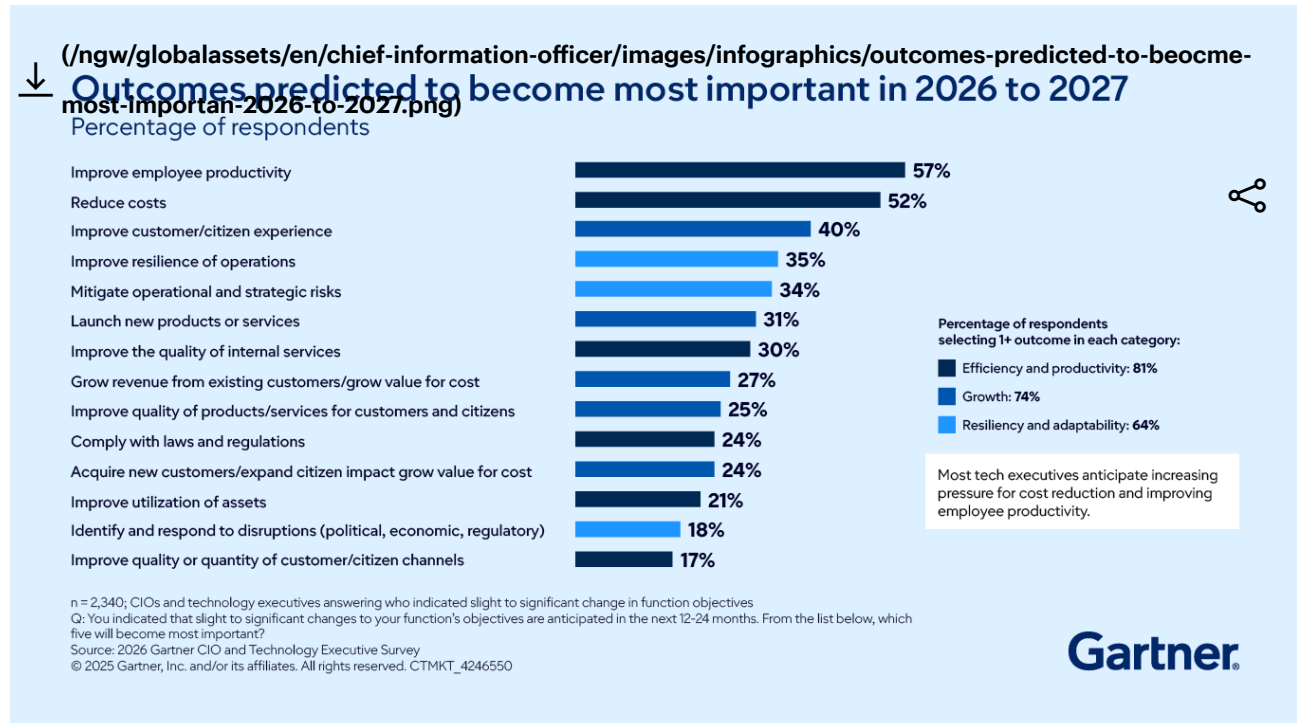


Strategic Pivots Will Define the CIO's Agenda in 2026

Three capabilities are the key to thriving in a turbulent, AI-driven world.

By **Daniel Sánchez Reina** (/en/experts/daniel-sanchezreina) | November 25, 2025



(<https://emt.gartnerweb.com/ngw/globalassets/en/chief-information-officer/images/infographics/outcomes-predicted-to-beocme-most-Important-2026-to-2027.png>)

Why strategic pivots matter now

Static plans won't survive in 2026. Economic volatility, geopolitical shifts and AI innovation are reshaping technology leadership, demanding leaders to pivot fast and decisively. According to Gartner's 2026 CIO and Technology Executive Survey, 94% of CIOs expect major changes to their plans and outcomes within the next 24 months, yet only 48% of digital initiatives meet or exceed business targets. The differentiator?

stering what Gartner calls the A.R.T. pillars — Agile realignment, Risk readiness and racity.

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How CIOs can win in 2026

Success will be about making bold, informed pivots. Here's how the A.R.T. framework helps leaders thrive in such uncertainty.

Agile realignment: Pivot at the speed of change

Annual or quarterly planning cycles are obsolete. Only 18% of CIOs embrace dynamic, off-cycle reprioritization today, yet those who do are 24% more likely to be top performers. Agility means:

- **Reprioritize dynamically:** Continuously assess resource allocation and discontinue underperforming initiatives.
- **Scenario plan boldly:** Anticipate disruptions and act decisively.
- **Build coalitions:** Secure cross-functional support to overcome resistance and enable rapid pivots when market conditions shift.

Leaders must make tough calls mid-flight and communicate the “why” clearly to keep stakeholders aligned.

Risk readiness: Navigate geopolitical and vendor complexity

Geopolitical turbulence and digital sovereignty laws are reshaping sourcing strategies. CIOs who proactively manage these risks are 51% more likely to outperform, yet only 28% do. Risk-readiness requires:

- **Geo-strategic sourcing:** Pivot from globally agnostic vendor strategies to regional mixes that balance compliance and scale.
- **Strengthen on-site support:** Ensure vendor presence in key regions to reduce operational risk.
- **Embed risk scenarios:** Make risk planning a core part of technology planning to safeguard continuity.

Think beyond cybersecurity. Risk-readiness now includes **tariffs** (</en/articles/cisco-tariff-strategy>), sovereignty laws and vendor nations — factors that can disrupt operations overnight.

Tenacity: Drive financial outcomes from technology

Cost pressures (</en/insights/cost-optimization>) remain intense: 57% of CIOs face pressure to improve productivity and 52% to reduce costs. CIOs who relentlessly pursue financial outcomes from technology initiatives — especially AI — are 25% more likely to excel, yet only 33% consistently do so. Tenacity means:

- **Be radically outcome-focused:** Prioritize initiatives that deliver measurable financial impact and secure C-suite alignment.
- **Translate gains into money:** Move beyond efficiency to cost savings and revenue growth.
- **Leverage AI-sourcing:** Use AI to bring work in-house, which can cut costs by 5% to 30%.

Three strategic pivots to watch

Beyond the A.R.T. framework, CIOs must prepare for three major shifts:

1. From GenAI pilots to AI (in any of its forms) ROI: Move from experimentation to measurable outcomes.
2. From globally agnostic to geo-strategically aligned sourcing: Adapt to data and AI sovereignty and compliance realities.
3. From calendar-based to trigger-based decision-making: Respond to signals, not schedules.

CIO Agenda FAQs

What is Gartner's CIO Agenda research?

It's Gartner's annual research based on the world's largest CIO and technology executive survey, revealing top priorities and strategies for the next 18 months.

Why are agile realignment, risk readiness and tenacity critical for CIOs?

These three capabilities enable CIOs to adapt quickly, manage geopolitical and vendor risks and deliver measurable business outcomes from technology investments.

How can CIOs prepare for agentic AI?

Start by aligning AI initiatives to business outcomes, upgrading governance and data readiness and piloting agentic AI in high-impact workflows.



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